

Week 6: Video Transcript

Hello everyone and welcome back to our sixth class module. Today we'll be making sense of mind sight and brain science. I'm so happy that you are here once again with me. I am Rebecca Lyddon, the director of education here at the Jai Institute for Parenting. I'm so excited to have this conversation with you today. So let's recap where we've been. It's important that we're continually looking back as we're looking right in front of us, and ahead in this process of integrating. So we began with your intention and I'm hoping that you are cherishing your intention throughout this entire process. Right when you wake up in the morning it's the first thing that you're thinking about. I'm hoping that as you progress through this process, you are seeing the tiny shifts, whether they are deep inside of you and they can't be seen, they're only felt, or maybe you are experiencing already dynamic shifts in the patterns in the way you are parenting with your children.

Maybe you're seeing more ease in your ability to connect with your child or children, partner or spouse. The sky is the limit as far as the miracles that occur in the first six weeks of this program. Remember that this is also a space of non-comparison, so we're not comparing, "Oh, I bet that I am not getting as good of results as the next person." That's not true. There is no one way to experience this process and my job is to remind you over and over again, that however you are being touched by this work, and however this work is translating itself through you, that is exactly how it is meant to be working right now in this moment.

I let you all know about nervous system science last week, so we're learning that we have a window of tolerance. And depending on how often you spend in your social engagement system, how often you can access a felt sense of safety, is going to determine the depth and the manifestation of this work on an interpersonal daily basis. We're not condemning, we're not making that bad or wrong. We are practicing unconditional acceptance. And from a place of unconditional acceptance, we develop greater safety. So the irony is not lost on me, that we are trying to strive toward expansion and growth while bypassing hard needs for safety. We're done doing that. That's all done. And it's time for us to really embrace that safety comes first, transformation thus follows effortlessly. It's no longer a doing, it's more of a receiving and an integrating. We went on into the 10 pillars of Empowered Parenting, and I encourage you all to continue noticing where you are already showing up in these pillars naturally.



Even if you were to put it on a measurement scale, you're only showing up in these 5% of the time. And congratulate yourself! 5% is a whole whopping 5% more than 0%, so I call that a win. Also notice how you are integrating these pillars on the inside. Remembering that every step of the way, that the way that we are able to show up for our kids begins and ends with us. So if you're in love with these pillars and you're wanting to grow, and you're wanting to show up more consistently and dependably in these pillars with your children, look in the mirror and get curious about how they're showing up within you and your relationship to self. Then we went into attachment science and this is the beginning of a microcosm and a dance of attachment science, nervous system science, and now we're here at brain science. So we've begun the stacking process. We've understood the absolute necessity of secure attachment within the self and the child in order for the pillars to bloom. And we understood at the nervous system level, what's happening beneath the surface of this attachment system at a physiological micro biological level, which to me is so exciting. We are combining the hands, the physiology of empowered parenting, today with the head of empowered parenting. We are stacking the next brick, which is understanding the brain's role within the constant conversation of the mind, body, and heart. This is not woo, woo. I am not being poetical. This is us understanding and embracing the next level of science that is showing us that mind-body feeling center integration. And I can't wait to keep going today.

So today we're discussing something called mindsight, and this was a term coined by Daniel Siegel, who is a neuroscientist and an interpersonal neurobiologist, and probably a whole bunch of other things that I can't remember. This is essentially our ability to see within the mind of someone else using our imagination, to try to understand what is happening inside of this person in their body, brain, heart, and in their desires, their longings, and in their imagination that is creating the way that they are showing up in this moment. It's a desire to understand, it's a desire to be curious. It's a desire to see someone unconditionally without judgment, labels, accusations, or assumptions. "Why on earth are they showing up this way? How utterly fascinating!" versus "What are you doing?" We all know that feeling when we're watching our child pour the bag of dog food all the way over on the bowl. And my insight is our longing to slow down, pause, and connect with what is happening inside the brilliant nervous system, brain, and heart of our children. It is such a gift because this is, as Daniel Siegel and Tina Payne Bryson share with us, the second S of earning a secure attachment with our children, if we're not insecurity thus far. And of course I'm holding up the mirror at every point in this journey, and I am declaring that the quality of mindsight we offer to our children to allow them to feel seen, really feeling it. They don't have the cognitive ability to understand that they are having their need for being seen met.

They're feeling it in their body and they're feeling like they're understood, like somebody gets them and that they make sense. Our quality of offering that to our children depends on the ways in which we are showing up for ourselves. As well as a longing to understand why we're thinking the things that we're thinking, why we are assuming, labeling, behaving, and living the way that we are, with curiosity and compassion, not condemnation or judgment.

We're going to work together today to understand the six barriers to embodying mindsight. I used the word embodying because we cannot intellectually allow our children to feel seen. We must be in relationship with feeling seen and really feeling our mindsight in our physiology, in our brain and our heart with our children for them to feel it. So what are the six barriers that keep us from embodying mindsight? You have a workbook this week, as usual, and I have all of this laid out for you. I'm going to take us step by step and elaborate a bit more. The workbook has an enormous amount of information that I can't seem to not give you, because I want you to know as much as you possibly can, so you can embody as deeply as you possibly can.

So the first one here is conditioned beliefs about children. We discussed this together already in week two, when we're understanding the power over or under parenting paradigm. The conditioned beliefs that we are raised with, most likely, are "Children are bad. Children are born manipulative, controlling, attention-seeking. They're here to get you. They're here to drive you absolutely crazy. They're here to strip you of everything. They're here to deplete you and exhaust you. They are out of control and need to be controlled, or else." Those may sound extreme, or they may sound normal for you. It really depends on where you are at in this process. Some of you may still believe those beliefs. Conditioning runs deep, and often the depth at which we believe these conditioned beliefs, reflect what we believe about ourselves. So if you were a child and were made to believe based on how you were treated, that you were bad, wrong, that you were unworthy, or you didn't matter, then you came to that conclusion potentially of all children, and then it's just continued to be given to us by every power that be as we rise and as we mature. So if you are heartbroken hearing these beliefs and part of your body is not willing to let go and truly surrender that these beliefs are not true, I want that to be okay. I want you to be honest, I invite you to be honest about that. That's something that your coach can help you with. It's counterproductive for us to pretend that we don't believe these things and fake it until we make it, that doesn't work. And I want us to be very honest and transparent with the person who is here to help you move through those conditioned beliefs, to find greater clarity and truth about children and who they are.



My belief is, and I offer to you, is that they are sacred. They are wise, they are born good, and they are born whole. This is a personal share, so please don't take this if this doesn't resonate with you, just set it down. I have been taught that children are our ancestors and they are our descendants. They are this symbol of the most pure love and relation that there could be. And that's something I carry with me in my heart when I'm struggling, and when I'm seeing my child as a "raging crazy maniac". I'm able to ground myself in an expansive belief about what is true for my child, or for children in general. So I would love to invite you to proclaim when you're feeling safe and secure in your body, because that's when to make proclamations of truth. Not when you're triggered or in fight or flight, that's not going to help you long-term. When you're feeling safe and secure in your body, begin getting curious about new beliefs that you could invite into your body, into your system, about what is true of children and just be playful and curious, and see how it shows up in your life.

So our second barrier is lack of awareness and education, and this is where brain science comes in. I am madly in love with neuroscience, and I am so excited that we have this information in our parenting. As I've said before, with attachment science and with nervous system science -- mothers especially, and fathers, parents, grandparents, caregivers -- this is instinctual when we are living from healthy instincts. Unfortunately most of us are living from a compromised intuition and instinct with prolonged state of fight or flight or prolonged stress. So I believe that when we are in a space of self secure attachment, security, and safety, understanding where a child is at in their brain development can be instinctual. We don't have to have the science for it. And because a lot of us are in insecure attachments and our connection to our intuition and instincts has been severed or wounded, we need science to validate and affirm what we already know is true, but is potentially buried. And neuroscience of course is absolutely complex. I could not possibly teach that to you here.

What really matters is the basics of brain development. We're going through the low brain, the middle brain, and the high brain. The most important conversation that we have here together is that while zero through seven, our children are in the back of the brain. This is inspired by Rudolph Steiner, if any of you are familiar with Waldorf Education or Anthroposophy. The first seven years is all about our children becoming into their body, becoming embodied and learning through touch, movement, and exploration. How to be in a human body is the basics of the brain. It is the unconscious systems like breathing, eating, learning how to know when you're hungry, learning how to know when you're thirsty, learning how to communicate those biological needs, play, warmth, and connection. Seven through twelve, our children are moving into the middle of brain.



This is when they begin to access their emotional regulator centers, and this is when they are learning how to expand their ability to understand feelings and needs, how to expand their mind sight past egocentric into the outer world. And this is just beginning from seven to twelve. It does not actually take flight until around eleven or twelve, depending on where your child is at.

And of course, every step of the way they're informed by developmental trauma and developmental wounding. If your child has not experienced a safe and secure attachment and the first eleven years of their life. Just because they're eleven, it doesn't mean that their brain is eleven. Just because they're seven, it doesn't mean that their brain is seven. So we have this list and these categories, and mindsight is about showing up to what is, not what we think it should be based on the diagram of : "where a kid is supposed to be" and "what they're supposed to be able to do right now". So I want this diagram to be of service for you, not a barrier in and of itself. I want this education to serve you into expansion and empowerment, not barrier or rigidity. Eleven through twenty-five, and some neuroscientists are arguing even later -- twenty to thirty, that is when the front of the brain begins to develop. And this is absolutely mind blowing, literally brain blowing, because the power over and under paradigm has required children to exist in a way that they are absolutely scientifically incapable of.

For example, following directions and having an understanding of why, being able to control their impulses, being able to self-regulate being able to have empathy and understanding for the impact of their actions on other people, being able to really use their logic and reason about why pouring the bag of dog food over a tiny bowl is not a good idea. That's not happening until eleven or twelve. This could expand into a conversation of the education system and its requirements on children to be able to sit still and stay focused on a task for an insane amount of time that their brain is not capable of. And actually requiring our children to exist in a way that they're scientifically incapable of brings our children into fight or flight. It does the opposite of what we're doing, or it brings them down into freeze or faint. So you might be thinking, "But Rebecca when I was five, I followed directions. I did what I was told. I thought about how my behavior would impact other people". And my response to you is thank you for sharing, and I'm so curious about any kind of memory you could also associate with that share where perhaps what could be true is you were following directions from your fear center, from the middle or back of your brain, rather than the front of your brain. Because I know that living in fear and stress, and assuming that a kid should be able to do X, Y, Z inhibits the development of the prefrontal cortex.

I understand learning this information can cause stress in your body. Maybe you are seeing by looking through this workbook and everything I have listed for you, that you are expecting your children to be a decade older than what they are. Maybe even two decades older than what they are. That can bring up feelings of embarrassment or humiliation, maybe resentment or anger, maybe annoyance and frustration, and maybe sadness and shame. Learning how to allow those feelings to come up and become curious of them. And my job will never be, "Oh, don't feel that. It's okay, you're fine. Don't feel that." That's not helpful either. My job is to give you permission to feel what you are, and to be able to practice naming it and practicing mindsight. "Where is this coming from? This feeling of shame that I feel in my chest. What thoughts are associated with this? What am I telling myself about myself as I'm feeling this feeling? Do I believe that I'm a terrible parent? Do I believe that I suck and I'm stupid? Where did that come from?" Self inquiry and self reflection, and it can be difficult to do without support. That's why you have a coach. That's why you have someone to help navigate that pathway for you.

So many words about this, and I have it written out for you in the workbook. I can't wait for you to speak with your coach about this. They're going to be able to support you. Let's go into the third barrier of practicing and embodying mindsight, which is seeing through a lens of judgment. This is a big one. So I have an entire list of qualities that are actually judgments and labels. We live in a society where good, bad, stupid, smart, lazy, disciplined, hardworking, all of those "good or bad" labels, they are labels. We tend to get quite rigid in our longing to attach a label to an experience. That's the brain's job actually. The brain's job is to understand what we are experiencing so we can make sense of it, and so we can integrate it into our system where we're able to exist and do more than one thing a day. We're learning how to see beneath the judgment in the labels, actually learning how to notice when you're in judgment and label, and learning how to see beneath. We have a beautiful process for you called root to bloom. This is allowing you to have a visualization of, let's say the child pouring the dog food all into a tiny bowl. That is the behavior that I'm witnessing, I might label that unwise. And then we have the roots. So I live in the Prairie and I'm surrounded by beautiful Prairie grasses, and we only see about this much of the plant. Most of the plants are a root system burying itself, way down into the soil. This is similar to anyone's behavior, especially our children. We see just a tiny bit of what's happening and then there's all of the roots, the feelings, the needs, the thoughts, the beliefs, the longings, the desires, the dreams, the wishes, the hopes, the motivations, and the patterns. And it's difficult for us to catalog all of that in a split second and inform our way of responding and inform our physiology and our brain. It's a practice and we're here to practice being able to catch ourselves when we're jumping into a label or a judgment.



The fourth barrier is fear and projection. So let's say that I was witnessing my child pouring the dog food into the bowl and I entered a state of fear. My amygdala was inflamed. So this is taught by Daniel Siegel, the brain, which is the model of the hand. We have the low brain, we have the brain stem, which is the amygdala, which is our stress center, our fear center, our aggression, and our anger center. Then we have the prefrontal cortex. When our prefrontal cortex is online or it's working, it's covering our brain's stem, our limbic system. When we are triggered into a state of fear, our prefrontal cortex is no longer protecting the brainstem. Our amygdala, our hypothalamus, and our hippocampus are all activated. What does that have to do with you in parenting? That's an excellent question. This is when our memory centers in the body are activated. So I taught you last time, how you're feeling the physiological sensation of stress and fear happening in the body. And this is showing us that it's in direct connection to the hypothalamus and the amygdala.

The amygdala and hypothalamus are communicating with the nervous system and deciding which hormones need to be flooded into the body to keep us safe. If we are having an emotional memory response, let's say that when I was a child, I would pour cat food into my cat's bowl and I would often make a big mess because my spatial awareness as a child was absolutely underdeveloped. I thought the bowl was a lot bigger than what it really was and my parent would come and get enraged with me and say, "Why are you so stupid? Why can you not see that the bowl is this big and you can't pour that whole bag over the bowl? What is wrong with you?" Then witnessing my child do something very similar that caused me an incredible amount of pain, fear, stress, and anxiousness in my body sent my physiology into fight or flight, activated my amygdala, activated my hypothalamus, and embedded itself into my implicit memory. Then of course, I'm going to have an implicit memory response, fear response, witnessing my child.

Our job, practicing mindsight, is being able to understand that that is happening, to be able to see it happening. And it's possible. I promise that it is. With practice, you will be able to see the layers -- just like root to bloom -- you will be able to see your own layers happening in a split second, find safety in your body, and show up how you want to. I know that it's possible, and with your coach, it will be possible for you too. Let's take something a little less intense and say that we're watching our child not do their homework. They're eleven or twelve and they're not doing their homework, they're bored. They don't want to do their homework and you're sitting over there like, "If they don't do their homework. They're not going to get into college, they're not going to get a job, they're not going to get married, they're not going to have children, I won't have grandchildren, and they're going to die alone! I'm going to die alone and everything is terrible!!" We spiral, and we don't even know that we're doing it.



We don't even realize until honestly working with a coach and having them ask you the next layers of your fear stories, that you are actually creating an Odyssey of fear unconsciously. And is that helpful? It's not helpful for anyone. It can be really kind of funny if you're willing for it to be kind of funny. The irrational fear that we attach to witnessing our children. What's not funny is that actually most likely why you are doing that is what I described earlier, which is your hypothalamus, hippocampus, and amygdala are being activated. And it's sending you into this state of stress and fear.

So number five is a lack of awareness and integration. I really appreciate this exercise because in our childhood, if we were not given the gift of mindsight, being seen, and understanding who we are, because the way in which we are perceived, reflected, and seen determines the way that we see and understand what is true about who we are. A lot of us in the power over or under parenting paradigm learned that in order to make it and survive, and secure acceptance and belonging, we had to show only 5% of who we truly are. We had to show only the qualities that we knew that our parents would praise. We believe that we had to show only the parts of ourselves that would secure us in a friendship group or a social group, and we believe that only certain qualities were good and certain qualities were bad.

So we were raised with a very limited understanding of what is actually true of who we are and a full integration of all of who we are. We contain multitudes, we're complex, we're contradictory, and we're full of paradox. And all of us are everything. I'm sorry, I'm getting a little bit poetical here. I cannot help it. All of us are everything, and we're learning that the ability to embrace all of ourselves, the parts that don't make sense, the parts that you didn't realize were there, the parts that you love or hate, those are going to determine your ability to see your children in those qualities. So let's say that I don't accept and embrace the qualities of me that are hardworking and diligent. This at one time was true and when I see my child being very focused, hardworking, and diligent, I don't understand why she cares so much about that. "Why do you care so much about that? It doesn't matter. Let's just go hang out and relax." So my ability to really understand those qualities within myself and embrace those qualities within myself, determines my willingness to exercise and embody mindsight with my child. So we have in the workbook, a few exercises for you to see yourself and to become more clear about what you've had to hide away in order to secure belonging and potentially what you are perpetuating with your children, as far as the qualities that you allow or do not allow in your home.



So number six is conditioned beliefs and limited self perception. So this is self-limiting beliefs. If any of you are familiar with the work of Dr. Bruce Lipton, he wrote *The Biology of Belief* and he is sharing and inviting the world to internalize, practice, and get curious about how 95% of our behavior, 95% of our brain's behavior, and our nervous system's behavior, is unconscious and subconscious. We're not in conscious control of it. We're not actually making a choice. It's more of a habit and a pattern playing itself off on a record player. It's the same habit and pattern, but it can be manifested in many different ways throughout our life. The same patterns everywhere, dictating our experiences, our perception, our choices, our behaviors, our reaction, all of this. What we've learned here is, especially in the context of parenting and childhood, is when we experience chronic unmet needs -- and specifically, in this context, we're talking about safety, being seen, and meeting our core needs in our childhood -- the brain has two jobs. Make sense of what is happening and assign a story to it. Second, make sure it never happens again. Our beautiful brain and our unconscious or subconscious, they're trying to keep us safe and they're trying to understand and categorize our experience. That's the brain's job. As a child, to come to the conclusion that "My need to be seen and to be safe is not being met because my parent is not capable of doing those things," would bring the child system to a state of such terror that they may not make it through that. So it's easier and safer for the brain within the child to come to the conclusion that "Mama or daddy are not seeing me accepting me and providing me with emotional, psychological, physical safety, because I am bad". That must be why. That's a lot less dangerous in the system to internalize that experience and to make sure it never happens again, than to name it for what it is.

First of all, that child's prefrontal cortex can't name it for what it is, so their ability to understand it is very egocentric. If we do not have someone talking us through our experiences and helping us understand our thoughts and our beliefs, and what we're internalizing mindsight from our parent or caregiver, then we internalize it. We take it personally and we create our personality around it. I have in the workbook for you, the nine core limiting beliefs that I hear from parents all over the planet, and we're going to begin the process of gaining compassion and forgiveness for these beliefs, for your brain's job of building your personality, making sense of your reality, and keeping you safe.

Unfortunately, most of us carry these beliefs within our subconscious into adulthood and into our parenting and they are incredible barriers to self secure, attachment, secure attachment with their child, the ability to self-regulate, the ability to understand ourselves, and thus be able to provide those for our children (which are the two S's in earning a secure attachment). Take a deep breath. You're working with a fantastic coach who is trained to do this work, so you are in good hands and you are going to begin the process of softening these beliefs. You're going to find expansion.

So moving forward, how do we strengthen our mindsight? And the first is to learn and to begin noticing when you are going into the beautiful left side of the brain and using logic with a child whose brain cannot match yours. Notice when you are going into invalidation or dismissal of feelings. Next week, we're going to learn all about verbal empathy and notice if you say things like, "Ah, come on. It's not that bad. Just brush it off. You're fine. Oh, why are you crying? You have no reason to cry. There's absolutely zero reason for you to be crying right now. You're fine." You know what I'm saying. And sometimes those things are coming out when you're stressed, when you're in fight or flight, and when you're disconnected, so you're not alone. I say those things sometimes too, we're wanting to notice them. And remember, last week I taught you the art of apology. We're wanting to apologize for those things. That's going to help our child feel seen, understood, and safe.

We want to next look beneath that behavior with curiosity. So I named this already as the root to bloom process and it's in your workbook. The next is to learn how to listen without lecturing, and you know if you're the parent who is going into lecturing mode. There's an example in the book the Power of Showing Up where the little boy walked into the bathroom and daddy had taken the plug out of the bathtub and the little boy became inconsolable in emotion. The parent began lecturing, "Well, if we keep the water in too long then it will start to create some kind of mold on the side of the bathtub, and it will maybe drain into the basement, I'll have to call the plumber and..." That child's brain is not hearing you at all, and that's okay if you do that too. We're noticing when we go into blah, blah, blah, blah mode when the child is crying, and lecturing is not helpful. Notice when you do that and go like this, [zipping mouth]. That's what I do. Sometimes I have to actually hold my lips shut and pretend I stapled them so I stop talking. I highly recommend it.

The fourth is to resist the urge to capitalize on our children's learning process. This is shame. Please let's stop shaming our children overtly and covertly, and I say that with an understanding of why shame could be coming up overtly and covertly. I see the mindsight behind these tendencies. This is something like, "Ha! I told you so, if you would have listened to me the first time, then you wouldn't have had to X, Y, Z." It's that: "I am superior to you and if you would have bowed down to my superiority and my prefrontal cortex, you wouldn't have to be having this kind of pain". And you know, when you do something in that energy too. We're wanting to get curious about where that's coming from, root to bloom every step of the way. What is happening for you in that moment, that those words are exiting your mouth? What is happening for you? Get curious about it and bring it to your coach and they can support you to soften that response.



The fifth is called sports casting, and this is a really lovely way to un-intrusively name what is happening for our children. So this is instead of, "Oh my God, good job you're so amazing, look at you go!" which I totally do because I get very excited. We're practicing something called sports casting, which is, "Oh, I see that you brought the chair to the table." A little bit boring, but very neutral, and we're wanting to learn how to begin lessening our over-dramatization of what we're witnessing our children doing and practicing neutrality. So being able to just simply name what you're seeing like a sportscaster, but sportscasters are very excited also. So I like to do a very exciting sports casting. You get to decide what's real for you.

Number six, how we strengthen mindsight is being able to differentiate "I can't versus I won't". A lot of parents will come and say something like, "Well, they just won't listen to me". And I'm saying, is it that they won't or they can't. And this is an opportunity for curiosity and discussion, really understanding where is your child at developmentally? Where is your child at, in their nervous system? Where is your child at insecure attachment? Those are actually what's dictating their ability versus their will. Just practicing, when are you in that mindset of, "They just won't do it" versus "Is it that true or is it that they can't do it?"

Number seven, the very last one is showing up for you and practicing your own mindsight. So this is daily reflection, even if your head is on the pillow and you're just kind of noticing what happened in your day. You're giving yourself a visual picture or you're naming it out loud, or you're writing it down on a list, whatever kind of learner that you are, what happened in your day? You can do this with your children also, having a mind sight of the day. This can be strengthened through self reflection and setting an intention every day. The last one is creating "I am" statements, and I discussed this earlier in the process when we were discussing limiting beliefs. Being able to access "I am" statements coming from self security, self truth, being able to access the parts of yourself that you've had to suppress, the qualities that you have judged, and learning how to let those peek out slowly in your parenting and in your daily life.

Thank you everyone for being here with me and gaining more clarity about how to practice mindsight with your children, how to show them that you see them, how to show them that you understand them, how to get curious about what's happening in their world. "Help me understand. I'm so curious, I saw you poured the bag of dog food into the tiny bowl. Help me understand, what was going on for you in that moment? Can you help me understand your thoughts? Or, I saw you scratch your sister, can you help me understand what was happening for you in that moment? I saw that you couldn't stop your hands.



I'm so curious how to support you with that next time. How can I be a helper for you." We're to really help our children become self-reflective, and the only way is if we're in a place of curiosity, investigation, and non-judgment. I'm so thankful that you are here doing this work. Next week, we're going to be going into making sense of emotional intelligence and discussing the third S of earning a secure attachment. I can't wait to keep going on this journey with you. Thank you so much and be well.

